

THE SHORT KING SERIES

BOOK TWO

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# The First Date Blueprint

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*From Hello to Goodnight Kiss. Without Making It Weird.*

## Messages

okay that was actually really fun

I know.

you know?? bold of you

You laughed the whole night. I think that tracks.

okay fair. so what now

We're doing this again. I'll send you something this week.

...I'd like that

# The Exact Playbook for First Dates That Lead to Second Ones.

The Short King Coaching

## WHO THIS IS FOR

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*"Getting the date was step one. Making her glad she came is step two. Most men never get a system for step two. This book is that system."*

This book is for the man who gets dates but can't convert them. The man who has a decent time, never gets a second date, ends the night with a hug and a vague 'we should do this again' that leads nowhere. If that's you, it isn't a you problem. It's a system problem.

First dates have a structure that works and a structure that doesn't. Most men are improvising the entire time. This blueprint removes the improvisation and replaces it with a clear framework built on how attraction and chemistry actually work.

## Before You Read This

This book assumes the date is already set. If texting is still the challenge, start with **Book One: She Replied. Now What?** and come back. If deeper confidence work is what you need, pair this with **Book Three: Unshakeable**. The blueprint gives you the moves. Confidence makes them automatic.

## INTRODUCTION

# Why Good Dates Go Nowhere

You've been on a date that felt fine and led nowhere. The conversation flowed. You both laughed. The bill came. You walked to the parking lot, said something like 'this was fun,' and drove home thinking it went well. Then the texts got slower. Then they stopped.

**Here's what went wrong: the date was pleasant. And pleasant is forgettable.**

Daniel Kahneman's peak-end rule tells us people don't remember experiences by their average quality. They remember two things: the most emotionally intense moment and how it ended. A date that stays flat and comfortable from start to finish has no peak and no strong ending. It fades. She doesn't dislike you. She just doesn't think about you again.

### THE PLEASANT DATE

Flat, forgettable, no peak moment. Kahneman's peak-end rule means she remembers the average — which is nothing memorable.

### TOUCH AVOIDANCE

Most men either never touch at all or go too fast. Touch is the most powerful non-verbal bonding mechanism humans have. Getting the calibration right turns a good conversation into genuine chemistry.

### THE WEAK EXIT

Men who don't know how to close a date leave women with a flat final impression that erases everything built before it. The ending is what she replays. You need a good one.

*"I've watched shorter men walk away from first dates convinced height was the problem. In almost every case it wasn't. The structure was. Once we fixed the structure, the results changed completely."*

## CHAPTER ONE

# The 24-Hour Ritual

### *Showing Up Ready Is Half the Battle*

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Most men put zero preparation into a date beyond deciding what to wear in the last ten minutes. The way you show up — your energy, your composure, your sense of ease — is almost entirely determined by the 24 hours before you walk in the door.

Sleep and nutrition directly affect cortisol and testosterone. Poor sleep spikes cortisol, which produces the tight, reactive energy that reads as nervous the moment you sit down. Maxwell Maltz showed in *Psycho-Cybernetics* that the brain can't reliably distinguish a vividly imagined experience from a real one. A focused mental rehearsal of the date primes your nervous system for the confident version of the evening — not the anxious one.

## The Pre-Date Checklist

- ✓ Sleep 7 to 8 hours the night before. Tired men are flat conversationalists.
- ✓ Eat a real meal earlier in the day. Low blood sugar makes you irritable.
- ✓ Move your body. A 20-minute walk or workout burns off excess nervous energy.
- ✓ Dress sharp, not impressive. If you need to look in the mirror three times, wrong outfit.
- ✓ Apply fragrance. Scent is one of the strongest memory-association triggers we have.
- ✓ Confirm the plan that morning with one clean text. No question mark.
- ✓ Arrive 10 minutes early. Settle in. Let her walk into your world, not the reverse.

In the hour before you leave: sit quietly, close your eyes, and run through the date as a confident man who is genuinely relaxed and curious about her. Not rehearsing lines. Running the feeling. Then go.

**What not to do:** no anxious social media checking, no re-reading old texts, no changing the venue plan last minute. All of it signals to your nervous system that something threatening is happening.

You want to arrive like a man who does this comfortably.

◆ CASE STUDY: REAL CASE: ANONYMIZED

*A client had been on six first dates in three months. Zero second dates. Same pattern every time. We looked at his pre-date routine: working until an hour before each date, arriving rushed, eating nothing, spending the drive over second-guessing the venue. He was arriving in low-grade anxiety every single time and had no idea. We ran one experiment: afternoon off, proper meal, 20-minute workout, mental prep at 6pm, arrived ten minutes early. He described the difference as feeling like himself for the first time on a date in years. She texted before he got home. Four more dates followed. Nothing changed about his height. Everything changed about his state.*

■ YOUR  
MOVE

Write down your prep plan for the 24 hours before your next date. Sleep time, meal, movement, outfit, departure time. Put it in your phone and treat it like a pre-game routine — because that's exactly what it is.

## CHAPTER TWO

# Venue and Arrival

### *Where You Go and How You Show Up*

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Most men pick a first date venue by thinking about what sounds impressive. Wrong framework. The right question: what environment makes this date as good as possible?

For shorter men, venue matters more than most coaches will admit. In loud, crowded, standing-room environments you lose real conversation, you lose seated intimacy that neutralizes height as a variable, and you lose control of the date's energy entirely.

**The two-location strategy** is one of the highest-leverage moves you can make: plan a main venue and a second spot in advance. After 45 minutes, suggest moving. *"I know a good place around the corner."* You make the decision. She follows. That leadership registers without either of you consciously noticing it.

## Venue Guide

✓ **COCKTAIL OR  
WINE BAR**  
GOLD STANDARD

Intimate, seated, quiet enough for real conversation. If you're a regular and the staff greets you by name, that's an instant status signal she registers unconsciously.

✓ **COFFEE OR  
DAYTIME**  
UNDERRATED

Lower stakes, easier to extend if it's going well, easier to cut short if it isn't.

✓ **ACTIVITY  
DATE**  
SITUATIONAL

Works well if you're better in motion. The activity creates natural shared moments. Follow it with a sit-down drink to build closing tension.

✗ **DINNER**  
AVOID EARLY

High pressure, long format, hard to escalate physically. If she suggests dinner, suggest drinks first.

**X CLUBS /  
CONCERTS /  
MOVIES  
NEVER**

These are parallel activities, not dates. You cannot build attraction where you can't hear each other.

## The Arrival Frame

Arrive before her. Not anxiously — settled. When she walks in, stand and move toward her with warmth and purpose. Don't wait at the table like you're being interviewed.

The greeting sets the touching baseline for the whole date. A genuine, brief hug that involves actual contact is far better than the side-lean barely-touching version that communicates you're afraid to be close to her. After the greeting, lead immediately: *"I got us a spot over here."* Move. She follows. That micro-frame runs all night.

## Strong Openers vs. Weak

|                     |                                                                            |
|---------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>X WEAK</b>       | "You look amazing." — Evaluating, pressuring, needy energy                 |
| <b>X WEAK</b>       | "So, how was your day?" — Flat, interview-style, no energy                 |
| <b>✓<br/>STRONG</b> | <b>"I was starting to think you'd changed your mind." [smile]</b>          |
| <b>✓<br/>STRONG</b> | <b>Callback from texts: "So. About that thing you said about [topic]."</b> |

#### ◆ CASE STUDY: REAL CASE: THE WRONG VENUE

*A client was taking every first date to the same upscale restaurant, thinking the quality signaled high value. What it was actually doing was trapping him in a two-hour, high-spend, high-pressure format with a woman he'd never spent ten minutes with. He switched to a cocktail bar where he was a regular. The staff greeted him by name. When the date was going well he could suggest moving on — which a restaurant bill doesn't easily allow. His first date at the new spot ended at a second bar, then a third. She texted before midnight: 'That was one of the better nights I've had in a while.' Same man. Different container.*

#### ■ YOUR MOVE

Pick your go-to Short King venue right now. One intimate seated spot where you're comfortable. Then pick a second location within walking distance for the move. Decide both in advance, not in the moment.



## CHAPTER THREE

# Conversation Flow

### *The Three Phases Every Great First Date Moves Through*

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The most common mistake on first dates is treating conversation like an interview: questions, answers, questions, answers. Everyone is polite. Nobody is attracted.

A great first date conversation is a shared emotional experience. The emotional contagion effect confirms that emotions are literally transferable between people. A man who is genuinely playful, curious, and engaged transfers those states. A man who is slightly anxious and performing transfers that too.

The three-phase structure below is the architecture of a conversation that creates attraction. It isn't a script. It's a map. You still bring your own personality and stories. The map just makes sure you're heading somewhere.

#### **PHA** Warm-Up (first 15–20 min)

**SE 1** Light, present, fun. The purpose is to relax both of you into the actual date. No deep questions, no heavy topics. Callbacks from your texts work perfectly here. You're making her glad she showed up, not proving you're worth her time.

#### **PHA** Depth (middle of the date)

**SE 2** Ask something real. Not what-do-you-do-for-work real. Actually real: what she's excited about, what she's working toward. Dale Carnegie identified this decades ago: the deepest human desire is to feel genuinely understood. Share something genuine about yourself too. A real opinion. A story that shows something true about who you are.

#### **PHA** Tension (final third)

**SE 3** The conversation slows slightly. Eye contact holds a beat longer. Things get left slightly unsaid. The most important rule in phase three: don't fill the silence. Most men relieve charged moments immediately because the tension feels uncomfortable. That silence is not awkward. It's chemistry.

## Bridging Between Phases

**PHASE 1 → 2**                      "Okay, serious question. And you have to actually answer."

**DEPTH QUESTION**                      "What are you actually working toward right now? Not the resume answer."

**PHASE 2 → 3**                      [Stop talking. Hold eye contact two beats. Smile slightly.]

◆ **CASE STUDY: KYLE — THE INTERVIEWER**

*Kyle was smart and genuinely interesting. His dates consistently ended well according to him, but women never responded to follow-up texts. When we reconstructed his typical conversation, the pattern was clear: he asked questions the entire time. Good questions, but relentless. There were no moments of tension. No phase three. One instruction: after 40 minutes, stop asking questions for five minutes. Just respond and share and let things breathe. On his next date a silence landed and instead of filling it he held eye contact and smiled. She reached across the table and touched his arm. That was the shift. Same man. The conversation just moved somewhere it hadn't been going before.*

■ **YOUR MOVE**

On your next date, actively track which phase you're in. Still in warm-up after 20 minutes? Ask a depth question. Still asking questions after 45 minutes? Stop and share something real instead.

## CHAPTER FOUR

# Touch Calibration and Flirting

### *The Physical Language of Attraction*

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Touch is the most powerful non-verbal communication tool available on a first date. More powerful than what you say, how you look, or how tall you are. Desmond Morris's intimacy research established that humans move through a predictable sequence of proximity and touch as attraction develops. Skipping rungs creates discomfort. Moving through them naturally creates connection.

For shorter men, touch is the great equalizer. Height creates a visual distance. Touch closes a different kind of distance entirely. A shorter man who touches confidently and at the right time creates more physical chemistry than a taller man who keeps his hands to himself all night.

## The Touch Ladder

|                          |                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|--------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>RUN</b><br><b>G 1</b> | <b>Incidental</b><br>Passing something, pointing at the menu. Establishing that touch exists in this interaction without making it a moment.                                                             |
| <b>RUN</b><br><b>G 2</b> | <b>Intentional &amp; Brief</b><br>Touch her arm during a laugh, then withdraw. Read her response. Does she lean in or pull back? That's your calibration data.                                           |
| <b>RUN</b><br><b>G 3</b> | <b>Sustained</b><br>Contact that lingers. Hand on her arm a beat longer than needed. This is where chemistry starts to feel physical.                                                                    |
| <b>RUN</b><br><b>G 4</b> | <b>The Hand</b><br>Cover her hand briefly on the table. Hold eye contact. Say nothing. The highest-tension single move available on a first date — and it costs nothing except the willingness to do it. |

**After each rung, read and calibrate.** Positive signals: she doesn't move away, leans slightly closer, starts touching you in return. Negative: she pulls back or stiffens. If positive, continue up. If negative, drop a rung and re-establish comfort before trying again.

## Flirting Checkpoints by Phase

### FIRST 15 MIN

Light teasing and playful push-back. Show you're confident enough to not just agree with everything.

### MIDDLE

The misinterpretation technique — playfully misread something she says in a flirtatious direction. The almost-compliment works here too: imply something flattering without fully delivering it. She leans in.

### FINAL THIRD

Less verbal, more physical. Longer eye contact, a slight pause before responding, tension you both feel but neither names. This is the pre-kiss zone.

#### ◆ CASE STUDY: REAL CASE — 5'5" CLIENT

*A client at 5'5" had told himself that touching would seem try-hard for someone his height, so he kept every date purely verbal. Good conversation. Intellectually interesting. Zero physical connection and zero second dates. We introduced the touch ladder, rung one only for the first two weeks: deliberate incidental contact with no expectations attached. By week four he used the hand move in phase three. She turned her hand over and held his. They kissed at the end of the night. He told me he'd spent three years believing height was why his dates didn't convert physically. It was never the height. It was the distance he was creating.*

### ■ YOUR MOVE

On your next date, commit to at least rung two by the halfway point. One intentional brief touch during a moment of genuine laughter. Read her response. Write down what happened. That's your calibration data for the next date.

# The Kiss and the Exit

## *How to Close the Date Like a King*

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The reason most first date kisses don't happen isn't that she wasn't interested. It's that the man waited for perfect certainty, perfect certainty never came, and he hugged her goodbye. The timing is never perfectly right. There is only a window — and either you act in it or it closes.

When two people have spent an evening building shared emotional experience, the arousal associated with it is looking for an outlet. The kiss is the natural resolution of tension that has been building all night. When a man doesn't go for it, he's not reading the room. He's letting a wave break into sand.

## The Last 20 Minutes

The kiss is the result of the last 20 minutes being run correctly. Slow down the conversation. Increase touch to rung three or four. Hold eye contact longer than feels comfortable — warm and settled, not aggressive. Let a silence land without filling it. That charged pause is where the kiss lives. Stay in it.

## The Kiss Signal Cluster

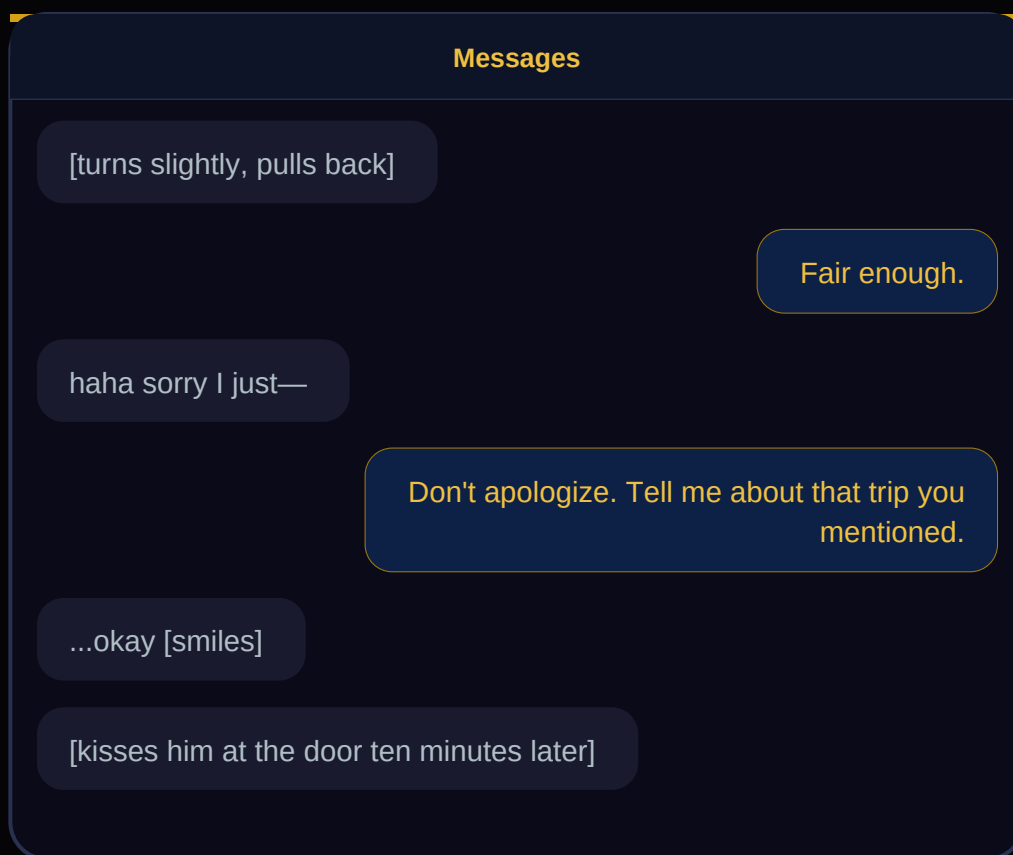
When you see three or more of these, the window is open. Act.

- She holds eye contact and glances at your mouth
- Her body is oriented toward you, not angled away
- She has touched you or allowed your touch without pulling back
- Her responses are getting shorter and warmer, less conversational
- Natural pause in conversation and neither of you rushes to fill it

## When She Hesitates

She pulls back slightly or turns her cheek. This is **not rejection**. **This is hesitation**. Pull back without making it a thing. No apology, no 'is this okay?', no wounded energy. Ease back with a slight smile, keep the conversation going like nothing dramatic just happened.

A man who handles the near-miss with complete composure signals exactly the kind of emotional steadiness that made her interested in the first place. In most cases she comes back to the window within minutes.



**Never say:** "Sorry, I read that wrong" or "Was that okay?" — No apology. No wounded energy. Just ease back and keep moving.

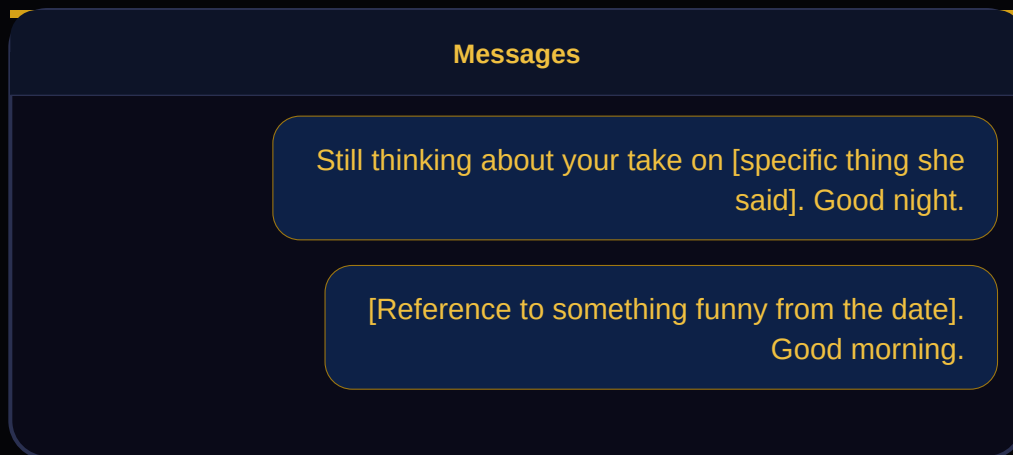
## Ending the Date

Leave at the peak, not past it. Men who keep talking past the natural ending point actively erase the impression built in the hour before. End decisively and warmly. Don't say '*I guess we should probably get going.*' Say '*this has been good, let's get out of here.*' Then make the physical goodbye count.

Before you part, set up the next interaction with a concrete direction. Not '*we should do this again sometime*' but '*we're doing this again. I'll send you something this week.*' You've already decided.

## The Follow-Up Text

That evening or next morning. One message. Specific and warm.



**Avoid:** long paragraphs telling her how great the night was. Avoid: "let me know if you want to do it again" — passive, puts it all on her.

### ◆ CASE STUDY: COMPOSITE — THE GRACEFUL MISS

*Two clients, same week. First went for the kiss at the end of a date that had gone well. She turned her cheek slightly. His previous pattern: apologize, make it awkward, date dies. This time he eased back, smiled, said 'still a good night' and kept talking naturally for four more minutes. As they were saying goodbye at the door, she kissed him. The kiss didn't come when he moved. It came when she saw how he handled not getting it.*

### ■ YOUR MOVE

Commit to going for the kiss on your next date when you see three or more signals from the cluster. Not when it feels perfect. When you see the signals. Act on information, not on certainty. Certainty is a story anxious men tell themselves to avoid acting.

# When It's Not Going Well

*Recovery Moves, the Post-Date Text, and the Path to Date Two*

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Not every date goes perfectly. Sometimes the energy is flat in the first twenty minutes. Sometimes she arrives distracted or closed off. Sometimes the conversation stalls somewhere in phase two and never finds its way back. Most men interpret this as rejection and coast to the finish line. The ones who convert second dates know how to read a struggling date and make a deliberate move to shift it.

The most important thing to understand about a flat date: **her mood at the start of the date is not a verdict on you.** She may have had a hard day. She may be nervous. She may have a guard up from a bad experience with someone else recently. The first twenty minutes of a date that starts cold can still become a date she tells her friends about — if you make the right moves.

## The Three Recovery Moves

### CHANGE THE ENVIRONMENT

If the energy has been flat for fifteen minutes at your current spot, suggest moving. Even walking to another bar around the corner resets the interaction. A new environment breaks the pattern associated with the flat energy and gives both of you a fresh start within the same date. Lead it — no vote required.

*I know a better spot around the corner. Let us move. — Then stand and move. She follows.*

### PHYSICAL PATTERN INTERRUPT

If you have been sitting in a neutral posture and things feel stiff, lean in with a direct observation or a light touch that breaks the physical distance. Stillness can compound flat energy. Deliberate movement resets it.

*Point at something, stand to look at the menu, shift your chair. Any deliberate physical movement that changes the dynamic without making it a moment.*



## GO DIRECT

Sometimes the most effective recovery is to name the energy without making it heavy. A calm, confident acknowledgment that things started slowly — framed as completely fine — is more disarming than pretending it is not happening.

*I feel like we both took a minute to warm up. That is fine. Tell me something you actually care about.*

## Knowing When to Cut It Short

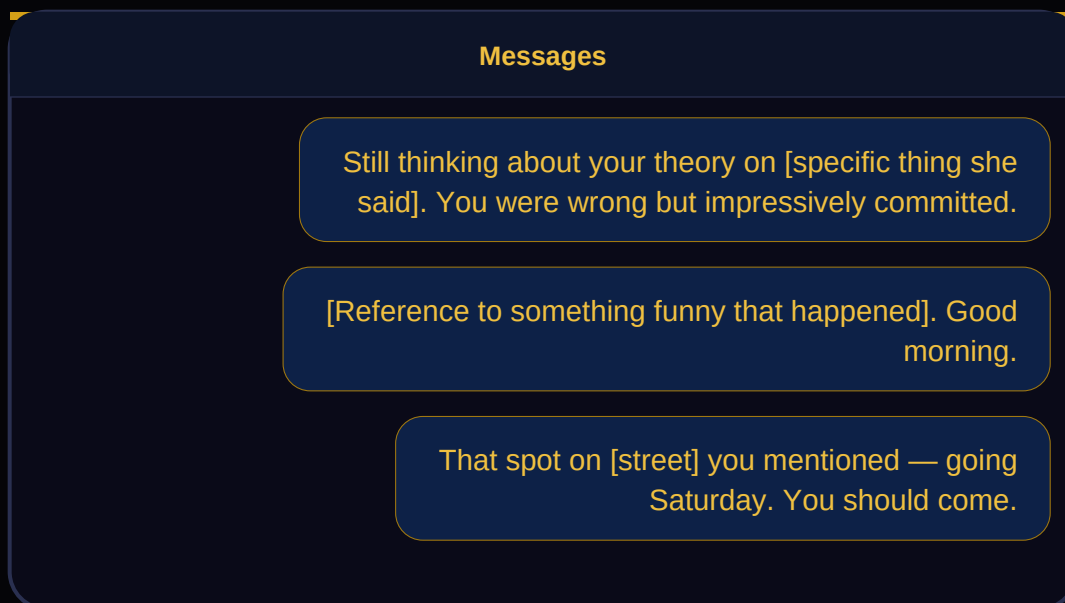
Not every date is salvageable and not every date should be. If after three genuine attempts to shift the energy the date is still flat, leaving after 45 minutes with warmth and zero drama is better than extending a dead interaction for two hours. A clean, confident exit is more attractive than an anxious one that overstays its welcome.

"This was a good start. I have somewhere to be. Let us pick this up another time." Then leave. No apology. No wound. The man who leaves a flat date on his own terms is more interesting than the man who stays hoping it improves.

## The Post-Date Text

The follow-up text is where most men either over-invest or disappear entirely. Both are wrong. The post-date text has one job: confirm the positive impression from the date while creating a specific forward pull toward the next interaction. It is not a recap. It is not a thank-you note. It is a single, specific, warm message that references something real from the night.

Send it the same evening or the next morning. One of these templates, adapted to what actually happened:

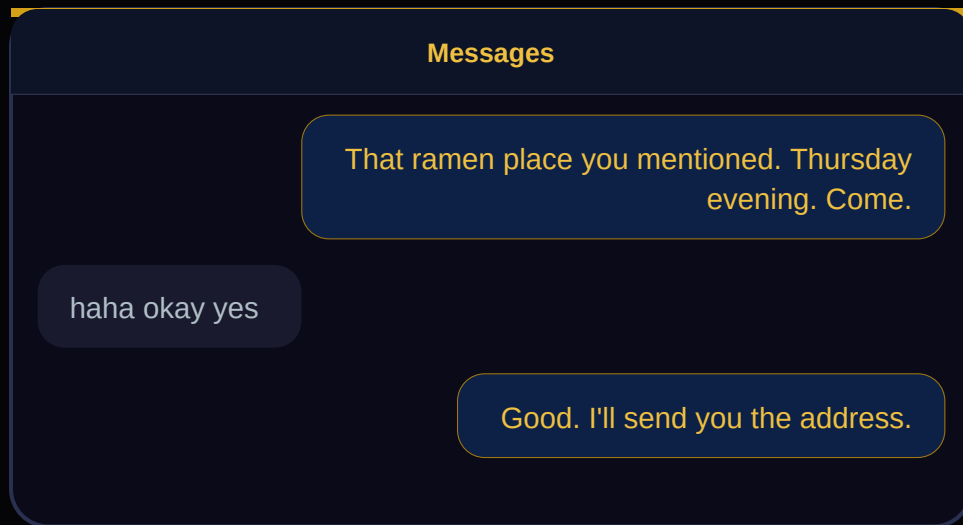


**Timing:** Same evening or next morning. Never more than 24 hours after. The longer you wait the more it reads as calculation rather than genuine interest.

**What to avoid:** Long paragraphs telling her how great the night was. "Let me know if you want to do it again" — passive, puts it all on her. Anything that recaps the date at length. The best follow-up texts feel like the conversation is continuing, not like it is being evaluated.

## Setting Up Date Two

The post-date text should contain or quickly lead to a specific proposition for the next interaction. Not 'we should do this again' but a concrete plan, stated as a direction rather than a question.



#### ◆ CASE STUDY: COMPOSITE — THE FLAT DATE THAT CONVERTED

*A client described a date that started badly: she arrived fifteen minutes late, checked her phone twice in the first ten minutes, and gave short answers to his first three questions. His instinct in the past would have been to try harder — more jokes, more questions, more energy to fill the gap. Instead he used recovery move three. He leaned back slightly, made direct eye contact, and said: 'I feel like we both needed a minute. Tell me something you are actually excited about right now.' She looked slightly surprised, put her phone away, and gave him a genuine answer. Forty minutes later she was still talking. She texted back within an hour of his follow-up. Second date was three days later. He told me afterward that the turning point was the moment he stopped trying to perform for the date and started being present in it. The recovery move worked because it was calm, not anxious.*

#### ■ YOUR MOVE

Write your post-date text template right now — before your next date. One sentence that references something specific from the conversation, one that creates forward pull. Save it as a draft. Then after the date, customize the specific detail and send it the same evening. Pre-writing the structure removes the overthinking that causes men to either send something weak or send nothing at all.

# First Date Quick Reference

*Screenshot this. Review it the morning of every first date.*

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## PRE-DATE CHECKLIST

- ✓ Sleep 7–8 hours
- ✓ Real meal earlier in the day
- ✓ 20 minutes of movement
- ✓ Sharp outfit decided in advance
- ✓ 60-second visualization before leaving
- ✓ Arrive 10 minutes early
- ✓ Confirm that morning — one clean text

## CONVERSATION MAP

- 1 Warm-up.** Light and fun. First 15–20 min.
- 2 Depth.** Ask something real. Share something genuine.
- 3 Tension.** Slow down. Hold eye contact. Let silence breathe.

## TOUCH LADDER

- R1** Incidental. Establish that touch exists.
- R2** Intentional & brief. Touch, withdraw, read.
- R3** Sustained. Chemistry starts here.
- R4** Cover her hand. Hold eye contact. Say nothing.

## KISS SIGNAL CLUSTER

- Eye contact held, glances at your mouth
- Body oriented toward you
- She has touched you or allowed your touch
- Responses shorter and warmer
- Natural pause, neither fills it

## THE EXIT RULE

- Leave at the peak. End decisively.
- Follow up that evening or next morning.
- One specific, warm message. Reference something real.

# The date is handled. Now let's fix what happens in your head.

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You have the structure now. The prep, the conversation phases, the touch ladder, the kiss framework, the exit. That's the external game.

But here's what I've seen with shorter men who have every technique right: they get to a charged moment and something fires in their head. *She's going to notice the height when we stand up. He's taller than me. She probably isn't that interested.* And the technique they learned correctly gets undermined by the internal narrative running underneath it.

**That narrative is the real opponent.** Not her height preference. Not the guy across the bar. The voice in your own head that has been running the same story for years.

## Unshakeable: The Short Man's Complete Guide to Confidence Under Pressure

*Book Three in the Short King Series*

- Cognitive reframes that dismantle height-based insecurity at the root
- Exposure drills that build confidence through action
- Self-talk scripts that replace the voice that fires at the worst moments
- Anti-rejection training that makes hearing no feel like data, not verdict

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*"You don't need to be taller. You need to be better. And better is built, not born."*

### **THE SHORT KING COMPLETE SYSTEM**

All seven books cover the complete picture: texting, first dates, confidence, presence, approach, attraction conversations, and dating profiles. Each works as a standalone. Together they're a complete operating system.

### **Want direct coaching?**

The books give you the system. Coaching gives you someone in your corner reviewing your real conversations, identifying where your specific game breaks down, and accelerating your results with direct feedback. Reach out through the Short King Coaching platform.

*The kingdom is built one date at a time.*